

Episode 12: Special Episode... Adventures Around Windows and Family Registers

It's been a while.

Actually, my father passed away early this month, and with all the related matters, plus the work piling up as a result - whoosh! - I've been taking a break for a while. Well, the work situation is still very much whoosh! continuing, but somehow... (distant stare).

So I'm starting again.

Well then.

Suddenly, but actually I'm still not quite back to normal, so this time is a special episode (bitter laugh). Moreover, it's not about anime at all... (sweat).

In anime, people actually die quite often, but when a person - just one person - dies, it's actually an incredibly difficult thing (bitter laugh). The dying itself is certainly difficult, but what comes after death is also very troublesome in various ways.

My father died in the hospital, and first they do "death determination" there. The doctor confirms no vital signs (pulse, heartbeat, breathing, pupil reflexes), and only then is "death" confirmed. The "died at what hour, what minute" thing. Based on that determination, the hospital issues a "death certificate." When you submit that to the city office and it's accepted, my father, who was a Japanese citizen, becomes "deceased" in Japanese society and is "removed from the family register."

With the funeral company arranged by the hospital, we returned home to discuss arrangements, leading to the wake and funeral. Since my mother had already passed away, I, as the eldest son, became the "chief mourner."

It had been 15 years since the last funeral, and since my father had handled everything as chief mourner last time, I honestly didn't remember much. Moreover, that time was right in the middle of production crunch for *Dragon Ball Z Movie: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans*, so except for the wake and funeral, I was at work the whole time... ah, that part was exactly the same this time (bitter laugh).

The funeral arrangements were left to the funeral company so that was OK, but what I had to arrange and contact myself were temple-related matters. Having the head priest from our family temple come, posthumous Buddhist names, offerings - man, I was nervous. I wanted to wake up my dead father and consult with him (laughs).

Still, somehow clearing the difficult challenges, we proceeded with the wake and funeral.

After the funeral, for cremation, you need permission for that too. You must get a "cremation permit" from the city office. And once he became bones, then you need burial permission. "Burial permit." Without this, no matter how much grave preparation you have, temples cannot perform burials.

Such permit harassment (bitter laugh). But these were all handled by the funeral company applying and receiving on our behalf, so there were no problems. What was difficult came after that.

I had to stop, change, or inherit various procedures from my father's social life.

Just government office-related: National Pension, Health Insurance, Elderly Health Insurance, Long-term Care Insurance... Then stopping bank accounts,

stopping and changing names for various utility automatic withdrawals, etc. Oh, and receiving insurance money. Moreover, several had conditions like "within 14 days of death"...

So I had to make rounds to various windows. The thing is, every single window is different (bitter laugh). Moreover, to apply and handle procedures at each one, you need family register copies, resident certificates, etc.

First, National Pension. This is the Social Insurance Office. For benefit suspension procedures, besides the pension certificate, you need a "death notification certificate" and the family register copy of the deceased person. Pensions are apparently paid through the month of death, which is fine, but since I'd stop my father's account, I as the representative heir would receive it. For that review - or rather, identity verification - I needed family register copies and resident certificates showing the relationship between my father and me.

National Health Insurance, Elderly Health Insurance, and Long-term Care Insurance are under city hall jurisdiction. However, Health Insurance is the Health Insurance Division, Elderly Health Insurance is the Welfare Division, Long-term Care Insurance is the Elderly Care Division - different departments and windows requiring separate procedures for each.

For stopping bank accounts, first they need the person's family register copy "complete from birth to death and removal from registry." Then since this becomes "inheriting" those deposits, they need family register copies, resident certificates, seal certificates, etc. for us inheriting siblings.

For utilities, I called everyone to arrange mailing of name change and account change procedure documents.

For life insurance (simple insurance), like banks they needed family register copies and such, plus since there was medical insurance, I had to go to the hospital where he was admitted to get "hospitalisation certificates" issued.

Incidentally, my family home is in Sayama City, Saitama Prefecture. I'm in Nakano Ward, Tokyo. And both my father and I had our family registers in Nakano Ward. So basic procedures were in Sayama City, and basic documents needed were in Nakano Ward - back and forth like that.

...What a hassle (bitter laugh).

Such things are never depicted in anime, right? There was the movie "The Funeral," but it didn't cover these procedural matters...

By the way, my father was a Sayama City resident in his later years, but originally had his family register in Tokyo's Nakano. So I went to Nakano Ward Office to get "complete from birth to death and removal from registry" family register copies. "Complete from birth to death and removal from registry" means copies are needed for every update of the family register due to marriage, children being born, etc. The copies they provided had various history of my father - marriage with my mother, mother's death, my birth, etc.

However, things didn't end at Nakano Ward Office. Actually, my father moved his family register to Nakano Ward after World War II, but originally, my father was born in "Tokyo City Ushigome Ward." "Tokyo City Ushigome Ward" is now Tokyo's Shinjuku Ward. So next, to Shinjuku Ward Office.

Waiting over an hour at Shinjuku Ward Office. The copy they provided clearly recorded my father's birth registration. Furthermore, this family register move to Ushigome Ward was two years after my father's birth, and in the true sense, my father's first appearance in family registers would trace back to Toyama City, Toyama Prefecture, where my father's father - my grandfather's - family register was.

Man, a bit moving. By following family register copies, I felt my father's 80-year life anew and firmly.

And various procedures are still incomplete and continuing (sweat). I wonder when they'll end...

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